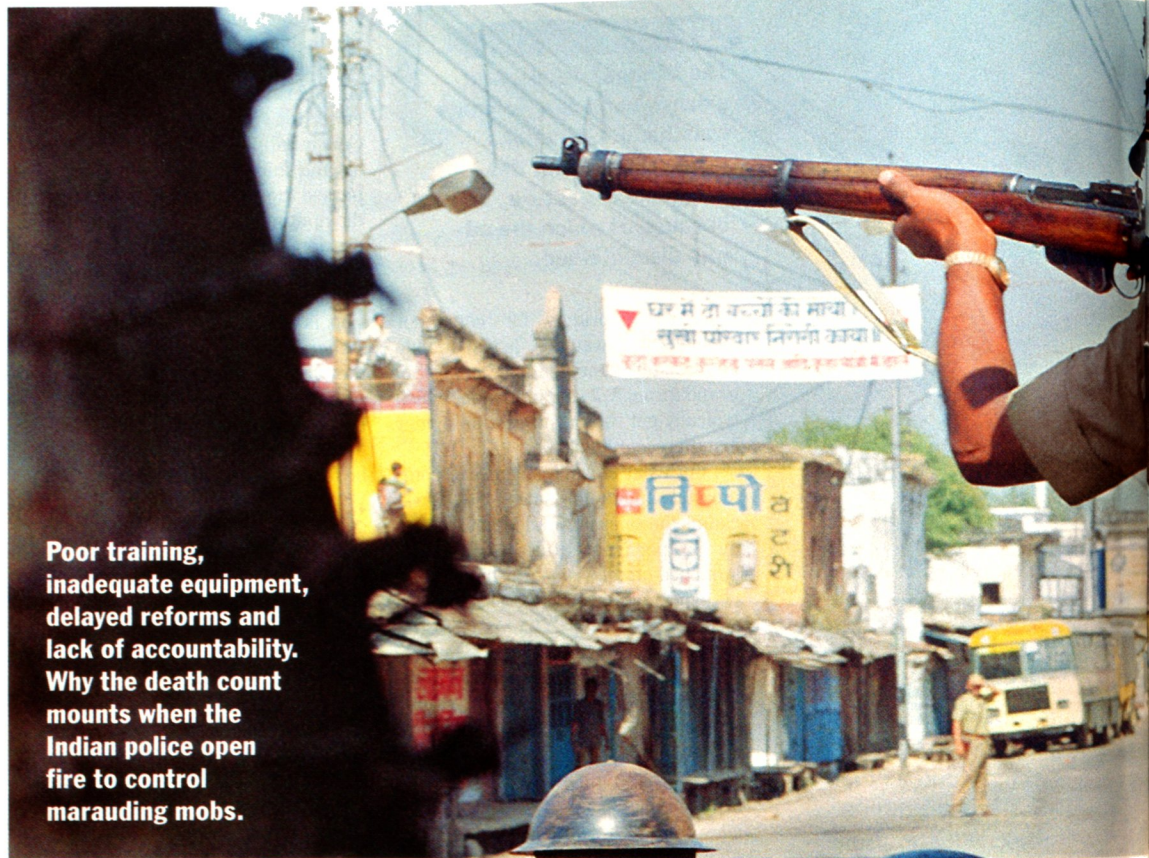




Poor training, inadequate equipment, delayed reforms and lack of accountability. Why the death count mounts when the Indian police open fire to control marauding mobs.

# SHOOT TO KILL

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

**O**n a hot Tuesday morning in Dausa on May 29, at the start of the Gurjar agitation, a mob of nearly 20,000 agitators advanced menacingly towards a police posse of 1,500 personnel, 400 of them armed. The district magistrate gave the order to fire and 15 minutes later, six rioters lay dead, further inflaming passions and fuelling the caste frenzy. The police decision to fire minutes before withdrawing from the scene has raised disturbing questions, as barely hours later six more persons died in a similar action in the nearby town of Bundi.

It's a familiar story. Be it Andhra Pradesh or Rajasthan, the police resort

to firing to quell rioting mobs, killing a few and wounding dozens. The ostensible justification for the act being the threat posed by the mob to their lives. The Criminal Procedure Code (CrPC) and state police manuals lay down the standard operating procedure when using force to disperse unlawful assemblies—lathi-charge and use tear gas. Firing, authorised by a district magistrate, is resorted to only in the face of a serious threat to life and property. Then, why the death toll?

In 2005—the only year for which statistics were released by the National Crime Records Bureau—44 persons were killed in police firing during riots and 198 injured. According to one independent study, between 1990 and 1999,

the police opened fire on as many as 5,994 occasions, claiming 1,753 civilian lives and injuring 6,886. "Our forces belong in the 18th century and our constables are not trained to tackle such situations," admits Madhukar Gupta, divisional commissioner of Jaipur range, who ordered the firing in Dausa.

Clearly, the procedures are not followed. Preliminary inquiries into the firing in the aftermath of the May 18 Mecca Masjid blasts revealed that instead of trying to chase and disperse a stone-pelting mob, members of Hyderabad police's Quick Response Team indulged in unwarranted firing, killing five persons. Not only did the police shoot at retreating agitators, they also flouted the norm of aiming below the